



Responding Safely

A guide for young people

Understanding Safety Risks

It's important to know that there are different kinds of risks you might encounter, both online and when you're out and about. Understanding these risks is the first step to staying safe.

Online Risks:

- **Cyberbullying:** This is when someone uses the internet, phones, or other digital devices to hurt, threaten, or embarrass someone else. It can happen through messages, social media, or gaming.
- **Online Predators:** These are adults who try to trick or groom young people online for their own purposes. They might pretend to be someone your age or offer gifts and attention.
- **Sharing Too Much Information:** Posting personal details like your address, school, or phone number can make you vulnerable.
- **Scams and Fake News:** Be aware of messages or websites that ask for personal information or try to trick you into giving money.

In-Person Risks:

- **Stranger Danger:** While most people are good, it's important to be cautious around people you don't know.
- **Peer Pressure:** Sometimes friends might try to get you to do things that feel unsafe or uncomfortable.
- **Getting Lost:** Knowing what to do if you get separated from your family or friends is crucial.
- **Unsafe Situations:** This could include things like being in an unfamiliar place alone, or with someone you don't fully trust.

Strategies for Staying Safe

Online Safety Tips:

- **Strong Passwords:** Use a mix of letters, numbers, and symbols. Don't share them with anyone except a trusted adult.
- **Privacy Settings:** Make sure your social media and app privacy settings are set to 'private'.
- **Think Before You Post:** Once something is online, it can be hard to remove. Consider if you'd be happy for anyone to see it.
- **Don't Talk to Strangers Online:** If someone you don't know contacts you and makes you feel uncomfortable, block them and tell a trusted adult.
- **Report Anything Suspicious:** If you see something that worries you or makes you feel unsafe, use the reporting features on the platform or tell an adult.

In-Person Safety Tips:

- **Stick Together:** If you're going out with friends, try to stay in a group.
- **Tell Someone Where You're Going:** Let a parent or guardian know your plans, who you're with, and when you expect to be back.
- **Trust Your Gut:** If a situation or person makes you feel uneasy, it's okay to leave or say no.
- **Know Emergency Contacts:** Have important phone numbers (parents, guardians, trusted adults) saved in your phone or memorized.
- **Be Aware of Your Surroundings:** Pay attention to what's happening around you, especially in new places.

Who Can You Talk To?

It's really important to have trusted adults you can talk to if something makes you feel worried, scared, or uncomfortable. This could be:

- Your parents or guardians
- A teacher or school counselor
- An older sibling or cousin
- A trusted family friend
- A coach or mentor

Remember, talking about it is a sign of strength, not weakness. These adults can help you figure things out and make sure you're safe.

Your Safety Activity: 'What Would You Do?' Scenarios

Let's put your safety knowledge into practice! Read the following scenarios and think about how you would respond. It's a good idea to discuss your answers with a trusted adult.

Scenario 1 (Online): You receive a message from someone you don't know on a gaming platform. They are asking for your real name, age, and where you live so they can 'send you a gift'. What do you do?

Scenario 2 (In-Person): You're at the park with friends, and one of them suggests going to a part of the park you've never been to before, which is known to be a bit isolated. You feel a bit uneasy about

it. What do you do?

Scenario 3 (Online): You see a post on social media that makes fun of one of your classmates. It's making them look bad. What do you do?

Scenario 4 (In-Person): You're walking home from school and a stranger in a car pulls over and asks if you want a ride. What do you do?

Scenario 5 (Online): You accidentally click on a link in an email, and a pop-up message says your computer has a virus and you need to call a number immediately. What do you do?

Staying safe is an ongoing process. By understanding the risks, practicing safe habits, and knowing who to talk to, you can navigate the world more confidently. Keep these tips in mind, and don't hesitate to reach out if you ever feel unsure or unsafe. Your well-being is the most important thing!